OPS · RESTART · 1/10

A restart is a vote, not a verdict.

What I've learned from hundreds of restarts — and what they actually prove.

10 slides · swipe

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The restart only clears memory.

It flushes what the process held — caches, connections, half-broken state. If the bug is in the data, the OS, the config, or the user's understanding — the restart publishes it again.

Restarts treat symptoms.
Fixes treat causes.

When a restart is genuinely the right move.

01 Known memory leak — process must periodically reset

02 Stale cache with a proven self-clear at boot

03 Deployed change, waiting for new workers to draw it in

04 Watchdog-confirmed wedge, not a data problem

If you can't name the mechanism, you're gambling — not operating.

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The restart illusion.

Someone restarts. Error stops. Ticket closes. Nobody adds the missing alert, fixes the bad query, or removes the poison message. The same failure lands in the queue next Tuesday.

Closed tickets aren't fixed bugs.
They're deferred incidents.

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Restart like an engineer, not like a superstition.

01 Capture the state first — logs, metrics, heap dump if cheap

↓

02 Restart — then verify the fix, not just the quiet

↓

03 File the root cause — assign it, with the evidence

↓

04 Close the loop with the alert that would catch it next time

A restart without a follow-up is an incident rehearsal.

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Signs your team restart-drives instead of fixes.

01 'Have you tried restarting?' is the only playbook

02 Same ticket ID keeps reappearing in the queue

03 Nobody captures state before bouncing

04 The postmortem is a Slack message with a shrug emoji

Two of these and your reliability is cosplay.

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What changes when restarts become evidence.

Failure patterns surface. Recurring ones become runbooks. Runbooks get automated. Automations get monitored. The restart frequency drops — and so does the 3 a.m. page.

Pattern first.
Script second.
Automate third.

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See the system, not the service.

PLAYER

Restart drama

'It works now'
no idea why
no idea for how long

ENGINEER

State forensics

what changed
when exactly
who else is affected

Capture before you clear — or the story dies clean.

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The restart law.

Before any restart: photograph the crime scene.
After: don't call it fixed until it can't happen quietly.

A symptom gone is not an incident closed.

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OPS · KEEP THIS · 10/10

Save this for your next incident.

Next 3 a.m. page: capture first, restart second, name the root cause third, alert fourth. Tape this above the on-call desk.

Save for later review

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